

CRISIS COMMUNICATIONS

The first 24 hours: a leader's desk guide

From My PR Partner. Keep it printed. You will not have time to look for it later.

When a crisis becomes public, the outcome is rarely decided by the incident itself. It is decided by the response, and most of the response is decided in the first 24 hours. This guide covers the three moves that matter most: categorise correctly, act in the right order, and communicate in a way people can actually hear.

1 First, get the label right: issue or crisis?

Mislabelling is the fastest way to escalate harm. Treat a crisis as an issue and you respond too little, too late. Treat an issue as a crisis and you inflict the crisis response penalty: unnecessary alarm and squandered trust. Before anything else, ask:

Does it threaten operations, safety or viability?

Could this materially interrupt what the organisation does, put people at risk, or threaten its licence to operate?

Are emotions running, or about to run, publicly?

Is the story spreading beyond the people directly involved? Are stakeholders frightened, angry or organising?

Will the response be judged, not just the incident?

If leadership's handling of the situation is itself likely to become the story, treat it as a crisis.

Mostly no: manage it as an issue and keep monitoring. Mostly yes: it is a crisis. Move to step two now.

2 The first hours, in order

Hour 1: Convene and hold the line

Assemble your response team, agree who speaks, and issue a brief holding statement that acknowledges the situation and commits to updates. Silence is read as indifference.

Hours 1-4: People before reputation

Address the people affected first, directly where possible, before the media and the general public. Stakeholders should never learn important news from a journalist.

Hours 4-12: Communicate in layers

Answer what people actually need to know, in the channels they actually use. Anticipate the next round of questions and prepare answers before they are asked.

Hours 12-24: Commit to the long game

Set a rhythm of updates and keep every promise, however small. Trust is rebuilt through kept commitments.

3 Say it so people can hear it

In a crisis, the people you are leading are in a fear state, and fear shuts down reasoning. This is why facts, statistics and legally polished statements fail on their own: **you cannot beat emotion with logic**. The Crisis Ready® formula taught in our Masterclass gives every communication three moves, in this order:

1 Validate

Name what people are experiencing and feeling, plainly and without spin. People who feel seen and heard can begin to trust. You do not have to agree with how they feel to validate that they feel it. And never follow validation with the word "but": it deletes everything said before it.

2 Relate

Show, as a human being, that you understand why they feel that way. Connection is the goal; it is what brings people out of survival mode and back to where they can listen.

3 Reassure

Only now provide the facts, the plan and the commitments. Prove your reassurance with action, and close with credible hope: what you are doing, by when, and how people will know.

The five mistakes that make it worse

1. Waiting for every fact before saying anything at all.
2. Leading with legal language while your community is frightened or angry.
3. Letting stakeholders hear it from the media first.
4. Overpromising in hour one and underdelivering in week one.
5. Treating the response as a moment instead of a months-long rebuild of trust.

BE READY BEFORE YOU NEED TO BE

The Crisis Masterclass, with Melissa Agnes.

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